

LIVE

Learning Space

NEWSPAPER

29th March, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

13th WEEK



MALE PREFERENCE & ASIA

UPSC CSE – GS I

GS I ... Salient Features of Indian Society.

6

Cousins under the skin

The obsession for a male child in many parts of Asia can be changed. South Korea shows the way



ALAKA M. BASU

On the Vietnam Airlines flight to Hanoi, I did the opposite of what I usually do at take off – loosened my seat belt fully before I could buckle it. On most other flights I have to tighten the belt to make up for the passenger who occupied the seat before me. But the Vietnamese are so slender that one can only buy their elegant Ao dai at stores that say 'foreigner sizes available'.

Equally non-threatening are the streets full of two-wheelers in Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City. Used to feeling extremely nervous at seeing groups of young men on two-wheelers in India, especially those that wave brightly coloured flags and matching scarves, it felt strange to have these Vietnamese young men negotiate my jaywalking without honking, without shouting slogans, and without baring their teeth. I am not sure if it was the men or their two-wheelers – mopeds and scooters rather than the more popular motorcycles in India – that had this effect. It was probably both. It felt as though the ravages of years of war had led the population to abandon rage for smiles.

Shopkeepers joined me in the game of endless bargaining, but they didn't nag me or block my way if I moved on without buying something. Perhaps this had something to do with the fact that a majority of petty shopkeepers were women. At about 77%, Vietnam has one of the highest female labour force participation rates in Asia.

Some comparisons

It felt good to be in a place where worth is not measured by girth, in humans or in vehicles. But first impressions can be misleading, so I turned to data. When I travel, I have the habit of comparing the place I am in with my home country – and ranking. But I do not look for data on the ease of doing business. I have no urge to do business and in any case, business ease is a poor way of measuring the well-being of a people. Instead, I look at quality of life indicators



and a country's attitudes towards its women.

In spite of a per capita GDP that is similar to India's, the difference in quality of life between the two countries is stark on a number of indicators over the past few years, although it may be narrowing, both because India's quality of life is improving and because Vietnam has been fast shedding many of its Communist-era commitments. Thus, according to the latest available figures of the World Bank and of various demographic and health surveys, the Vietnam government spent 3.8% of its GDP on health compared to India's 1.4%, and 5.7% on education compared to India's 3.8%. In Vietnam, 78% of the population has access to basic sanitation compared to 44% in India, 46% are covered by safety net programmes compared to 11% in India, and 12% of the population is below the poverty line of \$3.20 purchasing power parity per day compared to 60% in India. The infant mortality rate in Vietnam is 17 per 1,000 live births (India's is 35).

On other measures too, Vietnamese women have a clear edge over Indian women: a female life expectancy of 85 years (India's is 70 years); a maternal mortality ratio of 54 (India's is 174); of women of reproductive age being anaemic (24% com-

pared to India's 51%); of seats in Parliament occupied by women (27% compared to India's 12%); of females above 15 being literate (91% compared to India's 59%); of women having experienced domestic violence in the last year (9% compared to India's 24%); of women believing that men have a right to beat their wives for one of five (usually petty) reasons (28% compared to India's 47%).

As I scrolled down these indicators, I felt increasingly embarrassed about India's state. Obviously economic growth is not doing enough to improve some important things in India. The Vietnamese know something that India does not.

Preference for sons

Then, suddenly, I stopped short. India and Vietnam are, after all, cousins under the skin in at least one important way. Women might get a better deal in Vietnam than they do in India, but not in one crucial aspect: at birth, the sex ratio at birth, or SRB (the number of males born for every 100 females), is eerily similar in both countries. For perspective, in countries that do not actively prevent the birth of female babies, the SRB hovers between 106 to 108. If it crosses this range, it strongly suggests that there is sex determination followed by sex-selective abortion

taking place. The SRB has crossed this range in many parts of Asia and the Caucasus ever since sex determination technology became easily available, so Vietnam and India are not alone.

I suppose this is cultural, something to do with our common Asian heritage. There is a lot of writing about how the patriarchy, patriliney and male dominance in Asia outdo the patriarchy, patriliney and male dominance in the rest of the world and make families think that it is imperative that they have sons; that daughters are dispensable if a choice has to be made. In the past, female neglect and to some extent female infanticide were expressions of this mindset – now we have less guilt-inducing and less visibly callous ways of satisfying it.

Pallid national slogans like 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' or international calls for women's economic empowerment are unlikely to change things much. At the high levels of female education and labour force participation in Vietnam show, both education and jobs can coexist with a continued obsession for sons.

But culture is not immutable. This obsession for male children can be diluted with more practical policies to increase the substitutability of sons and daughters as well as the ability to manage with neither. This is best evidenced in the recent and rapid return in South Korea of the SRB from a peak of 116.5 in 1990 to a more 'normal' 107 today. Broader access to old age security, better prosecution of violators of laws against sex determination and sex-selective abortions, better enforced equal inheritance laws, and 'cultural' inducements such as allowing parents to choose either maternal or paternal surnames for their children seem to have all contributed not only to improving the status of daughters but also to lowering the value of sons. In turn, these measures have made women and families more indifferent to the sex of their children.

There are important lessons here for both the otherwise progressive Vietnamese as well as the still regressive Indians.

Alaka M. Basu, a professor in the department of development sociology at Cornell University, is Senior Fellow, United Nations Foundation

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

29th March, 2018

6 Cousins under the skin:

The obsession for a male child in many parts of Asia can be changed. South Korea shows the way. On the Vietnam Airlines flight to Hanoi, I did the opposite of what I usually do at take off — loosened my seat belt fully before I could buckle it. On most other flights I have to tighten the belt to make up for the passenger who occupied the seat before me. But the Vietnamese are so slender that one can only buy their elegant Ao dai at stores that say 'foreigner sizes available'!

Equally non-threatening are the streets full of two-wheelers in Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City. Used to feeling extremely nervous at seeing groups of young men on two-wheelers in India, especially those that wave brightly coloured flags and matching scarves, it felt strange to have these Vietnamese young men negotiate my jaywalking without honking, without shouting slogans, and without baring their teeth. I am not sure if it was the men or their two-wheelers — mopeds and scooters rather than the more popular motorcycles in India — that had this effect. It was probably both. It felt as though the ravages of years of war had led the population to abandon rage for smiles.

Shopkeepers joined me in the game of endless bargaining, but they didn't nag me or block my way if I moved on without buying something. Perhaps this had something to do with the fact that a majority of petty shopkeepers were women. At about 77%, Vietnam has one of the highest female labour force participation rates in Asia.

...Contd.



6 Cousins under the skin:

Some comparisons

It felt good to be in a place where worth is not measured by girth, in humans or in vehicles. But first impressions can be misleading, so I turned to data. When I travel, I have the habit of comparing the place I am in with my home country — and ranking. But I do not look for data on the ease of doing business. I have no urge to do business and in any case, business ease is a poor way of measuring the well-being of a people. Instead, I look at quality of life indicators and a country's attitudes towards its women.

In spite of a per capita GDP that is similar to India's, the difference in quality of life between the two countries is stark on a number of indicators over the past few years, although it may be narrowing, both because India's quality of life is improving and because Vietnam has been fast shedding many of its Communist-era commitments. Thus, according to the latest available figures of the World Bank and of various demographic and health surveys, the Vietnam government spent 3.8% of its GDP on health compared to India's 1.4%, and 5.7% on education compared to India's 3.8%. In Vietnam, 78% of the population has access to basic sanitation compared to 44% in India, 46% are covered by safety net programmes compared to 11% in India, and 12% of the population is below the poverty line of \$3.20 purchasing power parity per day compared to 60% in India. The infant mortality rate in Vietnam is 17 per 1,000 live births (India's is 35).

...Contd.



6 Cousins under the skin:

On other measures too, Vietnamese women have a clear edge over Indian women: a female life expectancy of 85 years (India's is 70 years); a maternal mortality ratio of 54 (India's is 174); of women of reproductive age being anaemic (24% compared to India's 51%); of seats in Parliament occupied by women (27% compared to India's 12%); of females above 15 being literate (91% compared to India's 59%); of women having experienced domestic violence in the last year (9% compared to India's 24%); of women believing that men have a right to beat their wives for one of five (usually petty) reasons (28% compared to India's 47%).

As I scrolled down these indicators, I felt increasingly embarrassed about India's state. Obviously economic growth is not doing enough to improve some important things in India. The Vietnamese know something that India does not.

Preference for sons

Then, suddenly, I stopped short. India and Vietnam are, after all, cousins under the skin in at least one important way. Women might get a better deal in Vietnam than they do in India, but not in one crucial aspect: at 111, the sex ratio at birth, or SRB (the number of males born for every 100 females), is eerily similar in both countries. For perspective, in countries that do not actively prevent the birth of female babies, the SRB hovers between 106 to 108. If it crosses this range, it strongly suggests that there is sex determination followed by sex-selective abortion taking place. The SRB has crossed this range in many parts of Asia and the Caucasus ever since sex determination technology became easily available, so Vietnam and India are not alone.

I suppose this is cultural, something to do with our common Asian heritage.

...Contd.



6 Cousins under the skin:

There is a lot of writing about how the patriarchy, patriline and male dominance in Asia outdo the patriarchy, patriline and male dominance in the rest of the world and make families think that it is imperative that they have sons; that daughters are dispensable if a choice has to be made. In the past, female neglect and to some extent female infanticide were expressions of this mindset — now we have less guilt-inducing and less visibly callous ways of satisfying it.

Pallid national slogans like 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' or international calls for women's economic empowerment are unlikely to change things much. As the high levels of female education and labour force participation in Vietnam show, both education and jobs can coexist with a continued obsession for sons. But culture is not immutable. This obsession for male children can be diluted with more practical policies to increase the substitutability of sons and daughters as well as the ability to manage with neither. This is best evidenced in the recent and rapid return in South Korea of the SRB from a peak of 116.5 in 1990 to a more 'normal' 107 today. Broader access to old age security, better prosecution of violators of laws against sex determination and sex-selective abortions, better enforced equal inheritance laws, and 'cultural' inducements such as allowing parents to choose either maternal or paternal surnames for their children seem to have all contributed not only to improving the status of daughters but also to lowering the value of sons. In turn, these measures have made women and families more indifferent to the sex of their children.

There are important lessons here for both the otherwise progressive Vietnamese as well as the still regressive Indians.

Cousins under the skin

The obsession for a male child in many parts of Asia can be changed. South Korea shows the way

6



ALAKA M. BASU

On the Vietnam Airlines flight to Hanoi, I did the opposite of what I usually do at take off – loosened my seat belt fully before I could buckle it. On most other flights I have to tighten the belt to make up for the passenger who occupied the seat before me. But the Vietnamese are so slender that one can only buy their elegant Ao dai at stores that say 'foreigner sizes available'.

Equally non-threatening are the streets full of two-wheelers in Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City. Used to feeling extremely nervous at seeing groups of young men on two-wheelers in India, especially those that wave brightly coloured flags and matching scarves, I felt strange to have these Vietnamese young men negotiate my jaywalking without honking, without shouting slogans, and without baring their teeth. I am not sure if it was the men or their two-wheelers – mopeds and scooters rather than the more popular motorcycles in India – that had this effect. It was probably both. It felt as though the ravages of years of war had led the population to abandon rage for smiles.

Shopkeepers joined me in the game of endless bargaining, but they didn't nag me or block my way if I moved on without buying something. Perhaps this had something to do with the fact that a majority of petty shopkeepers were women. At about 77%, Vietnam has one of the highest female labour force participation rates in Asia.

Some comparisons

It felt good to be in a place where worth is not measured by grits, in humans or in vehicles. But first impressions can be misleading, so I turned to data. When I travel, I have the habit of comparing the place I am in with my home country – and ranking. But I do not look for data on the ease of doing business. I have no urge to do business and in any case, business ease is a poor way of measuring the well-being of a people. Instead, I look at quality of life indicators



PHOTO COURTESY OF ALAKA M. BASU

and a country's attitudes towards its women. In spite of a per capita GDP that is similar to India's, the difference in quality of life between the two countries is stark on a number of indicators over the past few years, although it may be narrowing, both because India's quality of life is improving and because Vietnam has been fast shedding many of its Communist-era commitments. Thus, according to the latest available figures of the World Bank and of various demographic and health surveys, the Vietnam government spent 3.8% of its GDP on health compared to India's 1.4%, and 5.7% on education compared to India's 3.9%. In Vietnam, 79% of the population has access to basic sanitation compared to 44% in India, 46% are covered by safety net programmes compared to 11% in India, and 12% of the population is below the poverty line of \$1.20 purchasing power parity per day compared to 60% in India. The infant mortality rate in Vietnam is 17 per 1,000 live births (India's is 35).

On other measures too, Vietnamese women have a clear edge over Indian women: a female life expectancy of 85 years (India's is 70 years); a maternal mortality ratio of 54 (India's is 174); of women of reproductive age being anemic (24% compared to India's 51%); of seats in Parliament occupied by women (27% compared to India's 12%); of females above 15 being literate (91% compared to India's 59%); of women having experienced domestic violence in the last year (9% compared to India's 24%); of women believing that men have a right to beat their wives for one of five (usually petty) reasons (28% compared to India's 47%).

Preference for sons

Then, suddenly, I stopped short. India and Vietnam are, after all, cousins under the skin in at least one important way. Women might get a better deal in Vietnam than they do in India, but not in one crucial aspect: at birth, the sex ratio at birth, or SRB (the number of males born for every 100 females), is eerily similar in both countries. For perspective, in countries that do not actively prevent the birth of female babies, the SRB hovers between 106 to 108. If it crosses this range, it strongly suggests that there is sex determination followed by sex-selective abortion

taking place. The SRB has crossed this range in many parts of Asia and the Caucasus ever since sex determination technology became easily available, so Vietnam and India are not alone.

I suppose this is cultural, something to do with our common Asian heritage. There is a lot of writing about how the patriarchy, patriarchy and male dominance in Asia onto the patriarchy, patriarchy and male dominance in the rest of the world and male families think that it is imperative that they have sons; that daughters are dispensable if a choice has to be made. In the past, female neglect and to some extent female infanticide were expressions of this mindset – now we have less guilt inducing and less visibly callous ways of sacrificing it.

Paid national slogans like 'Betel Bachao, Beti Padhao' or international calls for women's economic empowerment are unlikely to change things much. As the high levels of female education and labour force participation in Vietnam show, both education and jobs can coexist with a continued obsession for sons.

But culture is not immutable. This obsession for male children can be diluted with more practical policies to increase the substitutability of sons and daughters as well as the ability to manage with neither. This is best evidenced in the recent and rapid return in South Korea of the SRB from a peak of 116.5 in 1990 to a more 'normal' 107 today. Broader access to old age security, better protection of violators of laws against sex determination and sex-selective abortions, better enforced equal inheritance laws, and 'cultural' inducements such as allowing parents to choose either maternal or paternal surnames for their children seem to have all contributed not only to improving the status of daughters but also to lowering the value of sons. In turn, these measures have made women and families more indifferent to the sex of their children.

There are important lessons here for both the otherwise progressive Vietnamese as well as the still regressive Indians.

Alaka M. Basu, a professor in the department of development sociology at Cornell University, is Senior Fellow, United Nations Foundation.

UPSC CSE – GS I

GS I ... Salient Features of Indian Society.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Giving preference to males is the deep-rooted cultural phenomena in several Asian Countries. Comment.

SOURCE:
LASAGONGMA SPRING
MT. GUOZONGMUCHA, CHINA



CHINA

East China Sea

NEPAL

INDIA

BANGLADESH

MYANMAR
(BURMA)

VIETNAM

Lao PDR

THAILAND

CAMBODIA

Bay of Bengal

South China Sea

Philippine S

Gulf of Thailand

MEKONG RIVER

MOUTH: SOUTH CHINA SEA

CHINA

INDIA

NEPAL

BANGLADESH

MYANMAR
(BURMA)

Lao PDR

THAILAND

Gulf
of
Thailand

Hanoi

VIETNAM

East China Sea

South
China
Sea

Philippine Sea

Bay of Bengal

FACT FILE ON VIETNAM



1 At 77%, Vietnam has one of the highest female labour force participation rates in India.

2 It's per capita GDP is similar to India.

PLEASE LOOK AT THE COMPARISON!

ISSUE	INDIA	VIETNAM
Govt. spending on health as % of GDP	1.4%	3.8%
Govt. spend on education as % of GDP	3.8%	5.7%
Access to basic sanitation	44%	78%
Safety net programmes	11%	46%
% of population below poverty line of \$ 3.2 PPP per day	60%	12%
Infant mortality for 1,000 live births	35	17

WHAT ABOUT INDICES PERTAINING TO WOMEN?

ISSUE	INDIA	VIETNAM
Female life expectancy	70 years	85 years
Maternal mortality ratio	174	54
Women of reproductive age being anaemic	51%	24%
Seats in Parliament occupied by women	12%	27%
Females above 15 being literate	59%	91%
Women having experienced domestic violence (in the last year)	24%	9%

BUT, WHAT ARE THE SIMILARITIES?

- 1 Sex Ratio at Birth (SRB) at 111 is similar for both the countries.
- 2 SRB is number of males born for every 100 females.
- 3 For the countries that do not actively prevent the birth of female babies, the SRB hovers around 106 to 108.

- 4 If it crosses this range, it suggests that there is sex determination followed by sex selective abortion taking place.
- 5 The SRB crossed this range in many parts of Asia and the Caucasus ever since sex determination technology became easily available.

So, India and Vietnam are not alone and this is cultural, something to do with our common Asian heritage.



UKRAINE

KAZAKHSTAN

RUSSIA

CAUCASUS MOUNTAIN RANGE

Black Sea

GEORGIA

ARMENIA

AZERBAIJAN

Caspian Sea

UZBEKISTAN

TURKEY

TURKMENISTAN

IRAN

SYRIA

Cyprus

SO, WHAT IS THE COMMON ASIAN HERITAGE?



- 1 The patriarchy, patriliney and male dominance in Asia is clearly evident, when we compare it with the rest of the world.
- 2 Families think that it is imperative that they have sons. Daughters are dispensable, if a choice has to be made.
- 3 In the past, female neglect and to some extent female infanticide were expressions of this mindset.

'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' or 'International calls for women's economic empowerment' are unlikely to change things much.

BUT, WHAT IS DIFFERENT IN VIETNAM?



- 1 High levels of female education and labour force participation show both education and jobs can co-exist even with a continued obsession for sons.
- 2 The preference for male children can be diluted with more practical policies.
- 3 This is clearly evidenced in the recent and rapid return in South Korea of SRB from a peak of 116.5 in 1990 to a more 'normal' 107 today.

WHAT ARE THE FEATURES THAT CAN CONTRIBUTE TO BALANCED SRB?



- Broader access to old age security.
- Better prosecution of violators of laws against sex determination and sex-selective abortions.
- Better enforced equal inheritance laws.
- Cultural inducements such as allowing parents to choose either maternal or paternal surnames for their children.

These are all contributed not only improving the status of daughters, but also in lowering the value for sons. These measures have made women and families more indifferent to the sex of their children.



*These are
important lessons
for both Vietnam
as well as India.*



WE EXPRESS OUR SINCERE THANKS FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

Presented by



Learning Space

For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

OUR TEAM

G. V. Rao
K. Srikanth
D. Sunil Kumar
L. V. Krishna
D. Chaitanya

Amrita Naidu
M. Binukrishna
G. Ravi Babu
D. Joji
K. Victor Babu

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0 8 6 6 -2 4 4 4 4 7 2
0 9 8 4 9 9 4 2 2 9 9